

Push your competitors to dig deeper and increase the gap between their offers; force them to leapfrog you with larger sums. Use this technique to chip away at *their* budget. You don't have to stick to the increments that the auctioneer is asking for – you can offer more. I've seen it work a treat.

Imagine this scenario (not to be taken as individual financial advice; this is just an example!):

- The auction sits at \$455,000
- Your competition bids \$1000, taking the price to \$456,000, but you don't hit back with another \$1000 jump ...
- Instead, offer a \$4000 bid. Now, your opponent is further behind where they hoped to be, and their next move – even if it is just another \$1000 – lands them at least at \$461,000, instead of the \$458,000 they anticipated would be their next bid. You have forced your competitor to find an extra \$3000. Do this repeatedly.

Don't exchange worried looks

Keep your eyes on the auctioneer at all times. Many newbie bidders, when they are nudging close to their financial limit, will turn to their company for a visual cue that they should keep going. A boyfriend or girlfriend responding with a pleading expression, while you hesitate, is the greatest giveaway that your budget is close to cooked, and your opponents will know they'll be able to skewer you with a few more bids.

Benson advises to never ask during the auction, 'Is it on the market?' It's a dead giveaway that you're weakening. 'The reading-between-the-lines ... is that you may be on your limit or close to it, and you want to know, "Can I buy it now? Can I please buy it now?" It's almost a plea.' This pausing and flinching will only encourage the auctioneer to seek stronger bids from elsewhere in the crowd.

Benson says first home buyers are often doing mental arithmetic as the auction rolls on. Each bid they have to lodge represents a sacrifice – 'If I place one more bid, that means we are not going to IKEA for six months, and if I place another bid, we are not going to Fiji in February' – and pain is written on their face. He says:

They are in a position where every dollar matters, and the catch-22 is it might take them longer to place a bid. Your hesitation can cost